

# REAL HELP FOR THE FAMILY

## INTRO

Preparing **A RICH AND HEARTY BEEF STEW**—a dish that takes **time, patience**, and the **right ingredients** to come together perfectly.

Start by **browning the beef**. Next, add ingredients and soften in the heat. Then, pour in a **generous amount of broth**

You add **seasonings—garlic, thyme, salt, and pepper—just the right balance to enhance the taste**. Finally, you lower the heat and let the stew simmer.

Now comes the hardest part: **waiting**.

The ingredients are all there, but if you rush the process, the meat will be tough, and the flavors won't blend.

**A GOOD STEW TAKES TIME**. You stir occasionally, adjusting the seasoning, making sure nothing sticks to the bottom.

After a while, you add **the secret ingredient**—a small splash of vinegar or a spoonful of sugar. **It's a tiny addition, but it unlocks all the flavors, making them come alive**.

**A HAPPY FAMILY IS MUCH LIKE THAT MEAL**—it requires the **RIGHT INGREDIENTS**. Love, kindness, respect, and patience.

But many families today face challenges, like **hurtful words**, **selfish attitudes**, or a **lack of communication**.

Thankfully, Jehovah, the Originator of the family, has provided a perfect recipe for success.

***families that follow God's principles can experience lasting happiness.***

Why?

# A1. CHILDREN SLOW TO RESPOND

IMAGINE traveled from a tropical island to the Arctic Circle. Can you adapt? Yes, but you will need to make a few adjustments.

A similar situation confronts you when your children become adolescents. Overnight, it seems, the climate has changed. The boy who once would not leave your side now prefers the company of his peers. The girl who once could not wait to tell you about her day now gives only clipped replies.

“How was school?” you ask. “Fine,” she replies. Silence. “What’s on your mind?” you ask.

“Nothing,” she replies. *More* silence.

*Not long ago, “it was like you had a backstage pass to your children’s lives,” says the book Breaking the Code. “Now the best you can hope for is a seat out in the audience, and it probably won’t even be a very good seat.”*

Should you resign? No. BUT you need to understand just what is happening during this stage of growth.

## Moving From Childhood to Adulthood

Researchers thought that a child’s brain was almost fully developed by age five changes little after that age, the same cannot be said of its *function*.

When they enter **PUBERTY**, young people begin a hormonal revolution that **changes the way they think**. For instance, while small children usually view things in concrete, black-

and-white terms, adolescents tend to think abstractly, weighing the underlying issues of a matter.

They develop convictions, and they are not shy about expressing them.

As they grow up, they want *reasons*, and perhaps even questions the values by which the family lives.

Sometimes his **ASSERTIVENESS LOOKS LIKE REBELLION.**

But do not conclude that your adolescent is out to overturn your values. He may just be struggling to make your values his own, to find a place for them in *his* life.

To illustrate, imagine that you are **MOVING FROM ONE HOME TO ANOTHER** and that you are taking your furniture with you. Will it be easy to find a place for each piece in the new home? Likely not. But one thing is certain, *you will not throw away any item that you view as precious.*

In a similar way, He/She is examining the values he has been raised with, and he is deciding which ones he will take with him into adulthood.

The idea of your child making such decisions may frighten you. You can be sure, though, that when he moves into adulthood, he will retain only the values that *he* views as precious.

Therefore, now—while your adolescent is still at home—is the time for him to investigate thoroughly the principles by which he will live

The Bible describes such a youth as being easily seduced because he is “in want of heart”—a phrase that means to lack discernment, among other things. (Proverbs 7:7)

A young person without convictions can be “tossed about as by waves and carried hither and thither by every wind of teaching by means of the trickery of men.”—Ephesians 4:14.

## Make sure that they are well equipped with **PERCEPTIVE POWERS**

The apostle Paul wrote that “mature people . . . have their perceptive powers trained to distinguish both right and wrong.” (Hebrews 5:14)

While small children may acquire a *knowledge* of right and wrong, adolescents need to “become full-grown in powers of *understanding*.”

We want them, not to obey blindly, but to use solid reasoning skills.

When talking to them, let him express himself. Do not interrupt, and try your best not to overreact—even if he says something that you do not want to hear.

**Bible Principles:** “Be swift about hearing, slow about speaking, slow about wrath.” “Out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks.”

Use questions rather than blunt statements. For example:

**If your adolescent says:** “I’m not sure that I believe in God.”

**Rather than respond:** “We taught you better than that—*of course* you believe in God!”

**You could say:** “What makes you feel that way?”

**Why draw out your adolescent?** The issue may have more to do with GOD’S STANDARDS than God’s existence.

Then you can help him to reason on the question, Do I really believe that God’s standards are for my good? ([Isaiah 48:17, 18](#)) If he believes that they are for his good, encourage him to see that his well-being is worth standing up for.—[Galatians 5:1](#).

**If your adolescent says:** “This may be *your* religion, but that doesn’t mean it’s *mine*.”

**Rather than respond:** “It’s *our* religion, you are *our* child, and you will believe what we tell you to believe.”

**You could say:** “That’s quite a strong statement. If you reject my beliefs, though, you must have something to replace them with. So, what are *your* beliefs? What code of conduct do *you* think it’s right to live by?”

**Why draw out your adolescent?** Because reasoning with him in this way can help him examine his thinking. He might be surprised to discover that his beliefs are the same as yours but that what concerns him is really something else altogether.

## **B1. Deeply Entrenched Bad Habits**

No marriage is perfect. All couples will encounter problems of some kind. Whether the issues are large or small, it is imperative that a husband and wife learn to resolve them. Why?

Over time, unresolved problems may become barricades that block communication. “There are contentions that are like the bar of a dwelling tower,” observed wise King Solomon.

(Proverbs 18:19) How can you open the door to more effective communication when dealing with problems?

## **B2. CAN BE OVERCOME**

If communication is the lifeblood of a marriage, then love and respect are the heart and lungs of the relationship. (Ephesians 5:33) When it comes to solving problems, love will motivate a couple to overlook past failures—and the resulting emotional injuries—and focus on the issue at hand. (1 Corinthians 13:4, 5; 1 Peter 4:8) Couples who show respect allow each other to talk freely and endeavor to hear what is meant, not just what is said.

# C1. STRONG COMMITMENT TO YOUR FAMILY

Imagine two houses—one built on a solid **rock foundation**, and another on **loose sand**. Both homes may look beautiful at first, but what happens when storms come?

- The house on **solid rock** stands strong, even against heavy rain and winds.
- The house on **sand** may seem fine for a while, but when challenges arise, it crumbles because it lacks a solid foundation.

A family with strong commitment is like a house built on solid rock. When a **strong commitment** to one another and to Bible principles forms the foundation, the family can endure hardships—financial struggles, misunderstandings, or even serious mistakes. **Rather than falling apart, they work together to resolve problems.**

A committed family that sticks together through difficulties will remain strong, just as a house with a solid foundation endures storms.